SOP Template Kit

Write procedures your team actually follows: guide, templates and 11 worked examples

A standard operating procedure (SOP) is a short, written way of doing a recurring job the same way every time, whoever does it. Good SOPs let you hand work over without losing quality, train new staff in days instead of weeks, and take time off without the business stalling. This kit gives you a method, two templates and eleven complete example SOPs you can adapt in minutes.

What's inside

Section	Use it to
1. Writing guide	Learn the eight rules of SOPs that work, with before-and-after steps
2. SOP master template	Document important or risky jobs in full
3. One-page quick SOP	Capture simple routines in ten minutes
4. Eleven worked examples	Adapt complete, realistic SOPs instead of starting from a blank page
5. SOP register, training sign-off and review schedule	Run your SOPs as a system, not a pile of documents

Three ways to use this kit

Fastest route: Open the example closest to your job (for example, 'Closing and cashing up'), save a copy, change the names, times and tools to match your business, and walk through it once with the person who does the job.

Writing a new SOP: Use the SOP master template for important or risky jobs, and the one-page quick SOP for simple routines. Follow the eight rules in the writing guide.

Running your system: List every SOP on the SOP register, record who has been trained on the training sign-off sheet, and review each SOP on the date shown on the review schedule.

1. Writing guide

Which jobs to write down first

Start with the jobs that score on two or more of these:

- Repeated often: daily or weekly jobs give the fastest return.
- Costly when wrong: money, customer complaints, safety, legal records.
- Done by more than one person, or only by one person (a key-person risk).
- Needed for training: the jobs every new starter must learn first.

Eight rules for SOPs people follow

1. Write for the newest person on the team

Assume the reader is competent but has never done this job here. Name the screen, the drawer, the form. 'Record the float' is vague; 'Count the float and write the total on the cash-up sheet in the red file' is followable.

2. One action per step, starting with a verb

'Check the order and pack it' is two steps. Split it. Verbs make steps scannable: Count, Check, Send, Record, Lock.

3. Say who, when and with what

Every step needs an owner. Add timing where it matters ('by 09:00', 'within 24 hours') and the tool used ('in the POS', 'on the courier portal').

4. Build the quality check into the step

A step is finished when its result can be checked. Add the check next to the step: 'Float = R1,000 in the agreed notes and coins', 'Tracking number pasted into the order'.

5. Explain the why only where skipping hurts

Most steps need no explanation. Add one line of 'why' to steps people are tempted to skip, such as backing up or double-checking a refund amount.

6. Plan for what goes wrong

List the three to five problems that really happen (the card machine is offline, the courier doesn't arrive) and what to do. This is the part experienced staff carry in their heads; writing it down is most of the SOP's value.

7. Keep it to one or two pages

If an SOP grows beyond two pages, it is probably two procedures. Split it and link them under 'Related documents'.

8. Give it an owner and a review date

An SOP nobody owns goes out of date. Name the owner, set a review date (every 6 or 12 months, or when a tool changes) and keep the revision history.

Before and after: turning vague steps into followable ones

Vague	Followable
Do the banking.	Take the cash bag to the bank by 10:00 and deposit it; staple the deposit slip to that day's cash-up sheet.
Handle the complaint properly.	Thank the customer, apologise for the experience and write the complaint in the complaint log before you reply.
Make sure stock is right.	Count each item on the delivery note and tick it; write any short or damaged items on the note before the driver leaves.

Rolling out a new SOP

1. Write the first draft by watching the job being done, or record yourself doing it.
2. Test it: ask someone who has never done the job to follow it while you watch without helping.
3. Fix every place they hesitated or asked a question.
4. Train each person who does the job and record it on the training sign-off sheet.
5. Keep the current version where the work happens: printed at the counter, pinned in the shared drive.
6. Review on the scheduled date, or immediately when a tool, price or law changes.

2. SOP master template

[Delete the grey guidance once you've filled in each section. Keep it to one or two pages.]

Field	Details
SOP title	
SOP number	SOP-0__
Area / department	
Owner (keeps it up to date)	
Applies to	
How long it takes	
Version and date	v1.0 ·
Next review	

Purpose

[One sentence: the outcome this procedure protects (money, safety, customer experience, compliance).]

Scope

[What the procedure covers and, just as important, what it does not (link the SOP that does).]

Roles and responsibilities

[Who does the work, who checks it, who approves exceptions.]

Tools, materials and access

[Systems, forms and equipment. Never write passwords or codes in an SOP.]

Procedure

[One action per step, starting with a verb. Put the check that proves the step is done in the last column.]

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			
11			
12			

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do

Records kept

[Forms, logs and files this procedure produces, and where they are kept.]

How we measure it

[One or two numbers that show the procedure works, e.g. 'opened on time on 100% of trading days'.]

Related documents

[Other SOPs, policies and forms.]

Revision history

Version	Date	What changed	By

3. One-page quick SOP

[For simple routines: fill it in, print it and keep it where the job is done.]

Field	Details
SOP title	
SOP number	
Done by	
When / how often	
Time it takes	
You will need	

#	Step	Done
1		☐
2		☐
3		☐
4		☐
5		☐
6		☐
7		☐
8		☐
9		☐
10		☐

If something goes wrong, contact:

Owner: _____

Last reviewed: _____

Example SOP-001: Opening the shop or office

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-001
Area	Front of house
Owner	Shop manager
Applies to	Every trading day, first staff member on site
Time needed	20 minutes
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Open on time with a safe, clean, working shop and a correct cash float, so the first customer gets the same service as the last.

Scope

Covers: Unlocking, alarm, systems, cash float, cleanliness check, messages and today's bookings.

Doesn't cover: Stock receiving (see SOP-004) and cash-up (see SOP-002).

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Opening staff member	Carries out every step and signs the opening checklist.
Shop manager	Holds the alarm code and float, checks the checklist weekly.

You will need

- Keys and alarm code (kept by the manager, never written in this SOP)
- Opening checklist (printed, in the counter file)
- Cash float bag and cash-up sheet
- POS terminal, card machine and receipt roll

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Arrive 30 minutes before opening and check the outside of the premises for damage or forced entry.	Opening staff	Any damage: do not enter alone; call the manager.
2	Disarm the alarm within the entry delay and lock the door behind you.	Opening staff	Alarm panel shows 'disarmed'.
3	Switch on lights, air conditioning, POS terminal and card machine.	Opening staff	POS logs in; card machine shows 'ready'.
4	Check there is power and connectivity; if load-shedding is scheduled today, note the times on the whiteboard.	Opening staff	Times written on the board.
5	Collect the float bag from the safe and count it in front of a second person where possible.	Opening staff	Float equals the agreed amount (e.g. R1,000).
6	Write the float total and your initials on today's cash-up sheet and load the till.	Opening staff	Sheet signed; till drawer closes.
7	Run a R1 test transaction on the card machine and void it.	Opening staff	Test approved and voided.
8	Walk the floor: clean counters, empty bins, check restrooms and remove trip hazards.	Opening staff	Opening checklist ticked.
9	Check emails, WhatsApp and online orders received overnight and flag anything urgent.	Opening staff	Urgent items written in the handover book.
10	Review today's bookings, deliveries and collections.	Opening staff	List pinned at the counter.
11	Unlock the front door and turn the sign to 'Open' at the advertised time.	Opening staff	Open on time.
12	Sign and date the opening checklist.	Opening staff	Checklist signed.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Float doesn't match	Recount with a second person; record the difference on the cash-up sheet and tell the manager before trading.
Card machine offline	Restart it; if still offline, switch to the backup mobile data hotspot and put up the 'cash or EFT only' sign.
Load-shedding during opening	Follow SOP-010 Power outage; trade with the battery-backed card machine and manual receipt book.
Signs of a break-in	Do not enter. Call the manager and SAPS; wait outside until help arrives.

Records kept

- Opening checklist
- Cash-up sheet (float section)
- Handover book

How we measure it

Opened on time on 100% of trading days; float differences under R10.

Related documents

- SOP-002 Closing and cashing up
- SOP-010 Power outage and load-shedding

Example SOP-002: Closing and cashing up

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-002
Area	Front of house
Owner	Shop manager
Applies to	Every trading day, closing staff member
Time needed	30 minutes
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Balance the day's takings to the till report, bank the cash safely and leave the shop secure.

Scope

Covers: Till count, card and EFT totals, banking bag, end-of-day reports, cleaning and locking.

Doesn't cover: Month-end reconciliation (see SOP-009).

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Closing staff member	Counts, completes the cash-up sheet and locks up.
Second staff member or manager	Witnesses the count and signs the cash-up sheet.
Shop manager	Reviews differences daily and does the banking.

You will need

- Cash-up sheet
- POS end-of-day (Z) report
- Card machine settlement slip
- Banking bag and safe

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Turn the sign to 'Closed' at closing time and serve customers already inside.	Closing staff	Door locked after the last customer.
2	Print the POS end-of-day report.	Closing staff	Report shows today's date.
3	Settle the card machine and keep the settlement slip.	Closing staff	Slip total matches card sales on the report.
4	Remove the float (agreed amount) in notes and coins and put it in the float bag.	Closing staff	Float equals the agreed amount.
5	Count the remaining cash twice, with a second person present.	Closing staff + witness	Both counts agree.
6	Record cash, card, EFT and other payments on the cash-up sheet and calculate the difference to the till report.	Closing staff	Difference written in rand, even if zero.
7	Explain any difference over R10 in the notes box.	Closing staff	Reason written or 'unknown' stated.
8	Seal the takings in a numbered banking bag and write the bag number on the sheet.	Closing staff	Bag number recorded.
9	Place the banking bag and float bag in the safe and lock it.	Closing staff	Safe locked; witness signs.
10	Switch off equipment that doesn't need to stay on and plug in the card machine to charge.	Closing staff	Card machine charging.
11	Check back doors and windows are locked and nobody is on site.	Closing staff	Walk-round done.
12	Arm the alarm and lock the front door.	Closing staff	Alarm armed confirmation.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Cash short or over	Recount; check for unrecorded refunds or payouts; record and report. Never take or add money to balance.
Card settlement differs from POS	Check for card transactions captured as cash; note it for the manager.
Alarm won't arm	Check doors and windows for an open zone; call the armed response provider if it still fails.
Staff member alone at closing	Bank the cash the next morning; do not walk to the bank alone after dark.

Records kept

- Cash-up sheet
- Z report and card settlement slip (stapled to the sheet)
- Banking bag numbers

How we measure it

Cash-up completed daily; differences over R10 explained 100% of the time.

Related documents

- SOP-001 Opening the shop or office
- SOP-009 Month-end admin close

Example SOP-003: Processing an online order

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-003
Area	Fulfilment
Owner	Operations lead
Applies to	Every paid online order
Time needed	10 minutes per order
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Ship the right items, well packed, on time, and keep the customer informed.

Scope

Covers: From payment confirmation to the tracking email.

Doesn't cover: Returns (see SOP-006) and stock receiving (see SOP-004).

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Packer	Picks, packs and books the courier.
Operations lead	Handles exceptions and checks the order issues log daily.

You will need

- Online store admin
- Packing station: boxes, filler, tape, printer
- Courier portal account
- Order issues log

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Open the order and confirm the payment shows as received in the payment system, not just on the customer's proof of payment.	Packer	Status 'Paid' in the payment system.
2	Print the packing slip.	Packer	Slip matches the order number.
3	Pick each item and check the SKU, size and colour against the slip.	Packer	Every line ticked.
4	Inspect each item for damage and replace it if needed.	Packer	No visible damage.
5	Pack with protective filler so the items can't move when the box is shaken.	Packer	Shake test passed.
6	Add the packing slip and any insert (thank-you card, care instructions).	Packer	Slip inside the parcel.
7	Weigh and measure the parcel and book the courier on the portal.	Packer	Waybill printed.
8	Attach the waybill to the largest flat side of the parcel.	Packer	Barcode readable, not covered by tape.
9	Paste the tracking number into the order and mark it shipped.	Packer	Customer's tracking email sent automatically.
10	Place the parcel in the collection area and get the driver's signature on the manifest.	Packer	Signed manifest filed.
11	Log any problem (out of stock, damage, wrong address) in the order issues log.	Packer	Issue logged the same day.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Item out of stock	Email the customer the same day with options: wait, swap or refund. Don't ship a partial order without agreement.
Proof of payment but no funds received	Do not ship. Wait for the funds to clear; proofs of payment can be faked.
Courier misses collection	Rebook on the portal and email the customer a new delivery estimate.
Wrong item shipped	Apologise, send the correct item at your cost and arrange collection of the wrong one.

Records kept

- Order notes with tracking number
- Signed courier manifest
- Order issues log

How we measure it

Orders shipped within 1 business day of payment; picking errors below 1 in 200 orders.

Related documents

- SOP-006 Handling a refund or return
- SOP-004 Receiving stock from a supplier

Example SOP-004: Receiving stock from a supplier

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-004
Area	Stock
Owner	Stock controller
Applies to	Every supplier delivery
Time needed	15–30 minutes per delivery
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Pay only for what arrived in good condition and keep stock records accurate.

Scope

Covers: Checking the delivery against the order, recording shortages and damage, updating stock.

Doesn't cover: Placing orders and paying suppliers.

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Receiving staff	Counts, inspects and signs for the delivery.
Stock controller	Updates stock records and resolves discrepancies with the supplier.

You will need

- Purchase order (PO)
- Supplier's delivery note
- Goods received note (GRN) book
- Stock system

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Find the purchase order for this delivery before you sign anything.	Receiving staff	PO number matches the delivery note.
2	Count the boxes against the delivery note while the driver is present.	Receiving staff	Box count agrees.
3	Open each box and count every item; tick each line on the delivery note.	Receiving staff	Every line ticked or marked.
4	Inspect for damage, expiry dates and wrong items.	Receiving staff	Problem items set aside, labelled.
5	Write shortages, damage and wrong items on the delivery note before signing, and ask the driver to sign next to them.	Receiving staff	Driver has countersigned the notes.
6	Complete a GRN with what was actually received.	Receiving staff	GRN totals match the physical count.
7	Put stock away in the correct location, oldest stock to the front.	Receiving staff	First in, first out.
8	Capture the GRN quantities in the stock system the same day.	Stock controller	System quantity updated.
9	Email the supplier about any discrepancy with photos and ask for a credit note or replacement.	Stock controller	Email sent within 24 hours.
10	Attach the PO, delivery note and GRN together and file them for payment.	Stock controller	Pack complete for the bookkeeper.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Driver won't wait for the count	Sign 'received unchecked, subject to count' and email the supplier within 24 hours.
Invoice higher than the PO price	Don't pay the difference until the supplier confirms it in writing.
Short-dated food or cosmetics	Refuse or set aside according to your agreement with the supplier.

Records kept

- Purchase order
- Signed delivery note
- Goods received note
- Supplier correspondence

How we measure it

Supplier invoices paid only against a matching GRN; stock count variances below 2%.

Related documents

- SOP-009 Month-end admin close

Example SOP-005: Handling a customer complaint

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-005
Area	Customer service
Owner	Owner or manager
Applies to	Any complaint, in person, by phone, email, WhatsApp or online review
Time needed	Varies; first reply within 1 business day
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Resolve complaints quickly and fairly, keep the customer, and learn from the cause.

Scope

Covers: Receiving, recording, resolving and closing complaints.

Doesn't cover: Refund mechanics (see SOP-006). Legal disputes go to the owner and your legal adviser.

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Any customer-facing staff	Listens, records and resolves within their authority.
Manager	Approves remedies above staff authority and reviews the complaint log weekly.

You will need

- Complaint log
- Order or booking records
- Remedy authority table (what each role may offer)

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Listen without interrupting, thank the customer for raising it and apologise for their experience.	Staff	Customer has finished explaining.
2	Get the facts: name, contact details, order or booking number, date and what went wrong.	Staff	Details complete.
3	Record the complaint in the complaint log before replying in detail.	Staff	Log entry created.
4	Check the order or booking records to confirm what happened.	Staff	Facts checked.
5	Offer a remedy within your authority (redo, replace, partial or full refund), or explain that the manager will reply.	Staff	Customer knows what happens next and by when.
6	Escalate to the manager within 24 hours if the remedy is above your authority or the customer is still unhappy.	Staff	Manager informed.
7	Carry out the agreed remedy and tell the customer when it's done.	Staff or manager	Remedy completed.
8	Follow up after 3–5 days to check they are satisfied.	Staff	Follow-up recorded.
9	Close the log entry with the outcome and the root cause (people, product, process, supplier).	Manager	Cause recorded.
10	Review the log weekly and fix repeat causes in the relevant SOP.	Manager	One improvement action per repeat cause.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Customer is abusive or threatening	Stay calm, end the conversation politely and hand over to the manager. Staff

	safety comes first.
Public online review	Reply publicly once, briefly and politely, then take the details to private messages.
Customer cites consumer law	Treat it seriously and escalate to the manager; check your obligations under the Consumer Protection Act with your adviser.

Records kept

- Complaint log
- Copies of messages
- Refund or replacement records

How we measure it

First response within 1 business day; 80% of complaints closed within 7 days.

Related documents

- SOP-006 Handling a refund or return

Example SOP-006: Handling a refund or return

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-006
Area	Customer service / finance
Owner	Manager
Applies to	Every approved return or refund
Time needed	15 minutes
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Refund the right amount to the right person once, and keep records your bookkeeper can follow.

Scope

Covers: Checking eligibility, receiving returned goods, issuing the refund, recording it.

Doesn't cover: Deciding complaints (see SOP-005).

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Staff	Checks the return and prepares the refund.
Manager	Approves and issues refunds; two-person rule above R500.

You will need

- Returns and refunds policy
- Original invoice or order
- Refund log
- Payment system

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Find the original sale and check it against your returns and refunds policy.	Staff	Sale found; policy terms checked.
2	Inspect returned goods and note their condition.	Staff	Condition recorded.
3	Calculate the refund amount, including or excluding delivery fees according to the policy.	Staff	Amount written in the refund log.
4	Get manager approval; refunds over R500 need a second person to check the amount and the account.	Manager	Approval initialled.
5	Refund to the original payment method wherever possible.	Manager	Refund reference recorded.
6	Never refund to a different bank account without verifying the request by phone on the number you already have on file.	Manager	Verification noted.
7	Tell the customer the refund has been processed and how long their bank may take.	Staff	Message sent.
8	Return good stock to stock and record damaged stock as a write-off.	Staff	Stock system updated.
9	File the refund log entry with the original invoice for the bookkeeper.	Staff	Filed.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Request to refund to a new account	Likely fraud. Verify by phone on the known number before doing anything.

Item returned damaged by the customer	Follow your policy; explain the decision in writing and escalate if disputed.
Duplicate refund	Check the refund log before paying; one refund per original sale line.

Records kept

- Refund log
- Credit notes
- Bank or payment system confirmation

How we measure it

Refunds issued within 5 business days of approval; zero duplicate or misdirected refunds.

Related documents

- SOP-005 Handling a customer complaint
- SOP-009 Month-end admin close

Example SOP-007: Onboarding a new client

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-007
Area	Client services
Owner	Account manager
Applies to	Every new client who has accepted a quote
Time needed	1–2 hours over the first week
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Start every client relationship with clear scope, contacts, payment terms and a confident first week.

Scope

Covers: From signed quote to the first progress check-in.

Doesn't cover: Sales and quoting.

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Account manager	Owns the onboarding and the client relationship.
Bookkeeper	Sets up billing and issues the first invoice.

You will need

- Signed quote or agreement
- Welcome email template
- Client onboarding form
- CRM
- Shared client folder

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Confirm the signed quote or agreement and any deposit received.	Account manager	Document filed in the client folder.
2	Send the welcome email and onboarding form within 1 business day.	Account manager	Email sent.
3	Create the client in the CRM with contacts, billing details and key dates.	Account manager	CRM record complete.
4	Create the shared client folder with the standard sub-folders.	Account manager	Folder shared with the right people only.
5	Book the kick-off call within the first week.	Account manager	Invite accepted.
6	On the call, confirm goals, scope, deliverables, timeline, contacts and how you'll communicate.	Account manager	Notes taken.
7	Send a written summary of what was agreed within 24 hours of the call.	Account manager	Client has replied to confirm.
8	Ask the bookkeeper to issue the first invoice or deposit request according to the agreement.	Bookkeeper	Invoice sent.
9	Set the first progress check-in date and add it to both calendars.	Account manager	Date booked.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do

Scope unclear after the call	Don't start work; send the summary with specific questions and agree before you begin.
Client slow to return the onboarding form	Remind after 3 days, then call; note any effect on the timeline in writing.
Deposit not paid	Agree with the owner whether to start; don't start custom work unpaid by default.

Records kept

- Signed quote
- Onboarding form
- Kick-off summary email
- CRM record

How we measure it

Welcome email within 1 business day; kick-off within 7 days for 90% of clients.

Related documents

- SOP-009 Month-end admin close

Example SOP-008: A new employee's first week

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-008
Area	People
Owner	Owner or HR lead
Applies to	Every new permanent or fixed-term employee
Time needed	Spread over the first 5 days
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Give new staff the paperwork, access, training and welcome they need to be productive and stay.

Scope

Covers: Before day one to the end of week one.

Doesn't cover: Recruitment and probation reviews.

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Owner or HR lead	Paperwork, payroll and policies.
Line manager or buddy	Daily training and check-ins.

You will need

- Employment contract
- Employee details form
- Policy pack
- Onboarding checklist
- Training sign-off sheet

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Before day one, send the signed contract, start time, dress code and who to ask for.	Owner	Employee has confirmed.
2	Prepare the workstation, uniform, keys and system logins.	Line manager	Ready the day before.
3	On day one, welcome them, introduce the team and show them the facilities and emergency exits.	Line manager	Tour done.
4	Collect the employee details form, banking details and copies of required ID documents.	Owner	Forms complete and stored securely.
5	Complete the payroll and statutory registrations that apply to your business (for example UIF), and confirm current requirements with your accountant or payroll provider.	Owner	Registration submitted.
6	Go through the policy pack (conduct, leave, safety, data privacy) and get it signed.	Owner	Signed acknowledgement filed.
7	Train the first three SOPs they'll use most and record each on the training sign-off sheet.	Line manager	Three SOPs signed off.
8	Hold a 10-minute check-in at the end of each day.	Line manager	Questions answered.
9	At the end of week one, agree goals for the first 30 days.	Line manager	Goals written down.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Paperwork incomplete	Don't run payroll until details are complete; follow up daily.

New starter overwhelmed	Reduce to the three most important SOPs; pair them with a buddy.
Personal information shared insecurely	Store employee records in a locked cabinet or access-controlled folder; protect personal information as POPIA requires.

Records kept

- Signed contract
- Employee details form
- Policy acknowledgement
- Training sign-off sheet

How we measure it

All paperwork complete by day 3; first three SOPs trained by day 5.

Related documents

- SOP Training sign-off sheet (in this kit)

Example SOP-009: Month-end admin close

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-009
Area	Finance
Owner	Owner or bookkeeper
Applies to	First 5 business days of every month
Time needed	2–4 hours
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Close each month with complete records, up-to-date debtors and a clear view of profit and cash.

Scope

Covers: Invoicing, reconciliation, receipts, debtors, reporting and backup.

Doesn't cover: Tax returns and annual financial statements (your accountant).

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Bookkeeper	Prepares the records and reports.
Owner	Reviews the results and decides actions.

You will need

- Accounting software or spreadsheet
- Bank statements
- Receipts folder
- Debtors list

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Invoice all work completed or goods delivered in the month.	Bookkeeper	No completed work left uninvoiced.
2	Capture all receipts and supplier invoices; chase missing ones.	Bookkeeper	Receipts folder empty.
3	Reconcile every bank account and card to the statements.	Bookkeeper	Reconciled balance equals the statement.
4	Review debtors over 30 days and send reminders; phone those over 60 days.	Bookkeeper	Every overdue debtor contacted.
5	Check that each supplier payment matches a GRN or approved invoice.	Bookkeeper	No unmatched payments.
6	Run the profit and loss and compare to budget and last month.	Bookkeeper	Report saved.
7	Note cash available, upcoming large payments and tax due dates.	Bookkeeper	Cash note written.
8	Review the results with the owner and agree up to three actions.	Owner	Actions written.
9	Back up the accounting data and the month's documents.	Bookkeeper	Backup confirmed (see SOP-011).

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do

Statement doesn't reconcile	Look for timing differences, duplicates and bank charges; don't force a balancing entry.
Missing receipts	Request copies from suppliers; record what's missing for your accountant.
Large overdue debtor	Stop further credit until paid and agree a payment plan in writing.

Records kept

- Reconciliations
- P&L report
- Debtors list
- Month-end note

How we measure it

Month closed by business day 5; debtors over 60 days below 10% of sales.

Related documents

- SOP-002 Closing and cashing up
- SOP-011 Data backup and account security

Example SOP-010: Power outage and load-shedding

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-010
Area	Business continuity
Owner	Shop manager
Applies to	Scheduled load-shedding and unplanned power or network outages
Time needed	5 minutes to switch over
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Keep serving customers safely and protect equipment and data when the power goes off.

Scope

Covers: Preparation, switching to backup, trading during the outage and recovery.

Doesn't cover: Installing backup power (an owner decision).

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Staff on duty	Switch over and keep trading.
Shop manager	Checks the schedule daily and keeps backup equipment ready.

You will need

- Load-shedding schedule app or website
- Inverter or UPS
- Battery-powered card machine
- Manual receipt book
- Torches

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Check the outage schedule for your area every morning and write today's times on the whiteboard.	Shop manager	Times on the board.
2	Keep the card machine, phones and torches charged before each scheduled outage.	Staff	Devices fully charged.
3	Save and close open work on computers 10 minutes before a scheduled outage.	Staff	Nothing unsaved.
4	When the power goes off, check that the inverter or UPS has taken over the essential equipment.	Staff	POS and router running, or noted as off.
5	If the POS is down, record sales in the manual receipt book with date, items, amount and payment method.	Staff	Every sale written down.
6	Switch off equipment that may be damaged by surges when power returns.	Staff	Sensitive equipment off.
7	Keep the entrance lit or closed for safety if it gets dark.	Staff	Safe entrance.
8	When power returns, switch equipment on one at a time.	Staff	Everything restarted.
9	Capture all manual receipts into the POS the same day.	Staff	Manual book and POS agree.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do
Inverter battery runs flat	Prioritise the card machine and one light; close temporarily if safety is affected.
No network for card payments	Use the mobile data backup or accept EFT only with proof cleared before handing

	over goods.
Fridge or freezer stock at risk	Keep doors closed; log temperatures and follow your food safety rules.

Records kept

- Manual receipt book
- Outage log (date, duration, impact)

How we measure it

No sales lost to unrecorded transactions; all manual sales captured same day.

Related documents

- SOP-001 Opening the shop or office
- SOP-002 Closing and cashing up

Example SOP-011: Data backup and account security

[Worked example. Replace names, times, amounts and tools with your own, then delete this line.]

Field	Details
SOP number	SOP-011
Area	IT
Owner	Owner
Applies to	All business devices and online accounts
Time needed	15 minutes weekly; 1 hour quarterly
Version	v1.0 (example)

Purpose

Make sure losing a laptop, a phone or an account never means losing the business's records or money.

Scope

Covers: Backups, passwords, two-step verification, access when staff leave.

Doesn't cover: Buying hardware and software.

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Owner	Holds admin access and the password manager; runs the quarterly checks.
All staff	Use their own logins and report anything suspicious.

You will need

- Password manager
- Cloud storage with version history
- External drive (kept off site)
- Account list

Procedure

#	Action	Who	Check / standard
1	Keep a list of every business account (bank, email, store, social, accounting) with its admin owner.	Owner	List current.
2	Store all passwords in the password manager, never in notebooks or spreadsheets.	Owner	No written passwords.
3	Turn on two-step verification for the bank, email, online store and accounting accounts.	Owner	2-step on every critical account.
4	Give each staff member their own login; never share the owner's login.	Owner	No shared logins.
5	Check weekly that cloud backup or sync completed for business files.	Owner	Last backup date this week.
6	Copy accounting data and key files to the external drive monthly and store it away from the premises.	Owner	Drive labelled with the date.
7	Each quarter, restore one file from backup to prove the backup works.	Owner	File opened successfully.
8	Remove access on the same day a staff member leaves, and change any shared codes.	Owner	Access removed and logged.
9	Report suspicious emails, payment change requests or log-in alerts to the owner immediately.	All staff	Reported the same day.

What can go wrong

Problem	What to do

Supplier 'changes bank details' by email	Verify by phone on a number you already have before paying; this is a common fraud.
Laptop stolen	Change passwords for accounts used on it and check the latest backup is complete.
Locked out of an account	Use the recovery codes kept in the password manager; record the incident.

Records kept

- Account list
- Backup log
- Access removal log

How we measure it

Weekly backup confirmed 52 weeks a year; quarterly restore test passed.

Related documents

- SOP-009 Month-end admin close
- SOP-008 A new employee's first week

5. Running your SOP system

SOP register

SOP no.	Title	Owner	Version	Last review	Next review
SOP-001	Opening the shop or office	Shop manager	v1.0		
SOP-002	Closing and cashing up	Shop manager	v1.0		
SOP-003	Processing an online order	Operations lead	v1.0		
SOP-004	Receiving stock from a supplier	Stock controller	v1.0		
SOP-005	Handling a customer complaint	Owner or manager	v1.0		
SOP-006	Handling a refund or return	Manager	v1.0		
SOP-007	Onboarding a new client	Account manager	v1.0		
SOP-008	A new employee's first week	Owner or HR lead	v1.0		
SOP-009	Month-end admin close	Owner or bookkeeper	v1.0		
SOP-010	Power outage and load-shedding	Shop manager	v1.0		
SOP-011	Data backup and account security	Owner	v1.0		

Training sign-off sheet

Record each person trained on each SOP. Both the trainer and the trainee sign once the trainee has done the job correctly without help.

Employee	SOP no.	Trained by	Date	Employee signature	Trainer signature

Review schedule

Review each SOP at least once a year, and straight away when a tool, price, supplier or law changes.

SOP no.	Review due	Reviewed by	Changes made?	New version

These example SOPs are general operating guidance for small businesses. They are not legal, tax or labour-law advice: confirm statutory requirements with your accountant, attorney or the relevant authority.